Another domain where Mookerjee's views remain an inspiration is that of cultural diplomacy. As the president of the Maha Bodhi Society of India, Mookerjee was also the driving force in forging links with Buddhist nations, especially neighbours. He played a personal role in the return of holy relics from the UK and their display in Southeast Asia, including Myanmar. Today, those initiatives are being further developed through recent activities like the Dharma-Dhamma conferences, restoration of the Ananda Temple in Bagan, solarification of Buddhist sites in Sri Lanka and digitization of manuscripts in Mongolia's Gandan monastery. Indeed, the importance we attach to our Buddhist heritage was only underlined by the visit of G20 Development Ministers to Sarnath. Obviously, Mookerjee's cultural interests were much broader and must be assessed in terms of its relevance to the anti-colonial struggle. Our endeavours at deepening cultural rebalancing would surely resonate with his views about the salience of that domain.

DR AMBEDKAR AND 'INDIA FIRST'

Among the founding fathers of modern India, Dr B.R. Ambedkar is widely recognized as the architect of India's Constitution and the strongest voice for social justice and inclusiveness. He was different from many of his contemporaries in being exposed to American society through his educational experiences. As the first Minister of Law and Justice, he served in the cabinet of independent India for little more than four years. When he resigned in September 1951, the main reasons were his dissatisfaction on a range of issues pertaining to social reform. But interestingly, Ambedkar also shared with Parliament his 'actual anxiety and even worry' about the directions of foreign policy. In his view, few countries wished us ill at the time when we attained independence. However, within four years, he felt that we had alienated much of the world and that this was visible in the lack of support for India at the UN.

Ambedkar, on that occasion, quoted two realists in a manner that is relevant even today. One was Bismarck, with the observation that politics is not a game of realizing the ideal; it is the game of the possible. The other was George Bernard Shaw, to the effect that while good ideals are good, one must not forget that it is often dangerous to be too good! It would seem